



Notes

Jul 21, 2026

Agent Ecosystem Working Group 2: Agent Adoption and Operations - MACH Alliance

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Summary

Meeting strategy session prioritized consequential ROI content and finalized production timelines alongside essential AI governance frameworks.

Strategy and Publication Timeline

The group prioritized consequential return on investment for content creation. They set a firm production deadline of September 4 to avoid summer engagement lulls.

Governance and ROI Frameworks

Discussions highlighted that scaling AI requires shifting from simple pilots to managed enterprise software via robust data infrastructure. Participants agreed to structure ROI metrics into front-of-house and back-of-house categories.

Finalizing Deliverables and Assignments

The team decided to publish two separate articles covering foundational investments and AI specific return on investment calculations. Authors were assigned to lead these distinct content workstreams.

Decisions

Aligned

- **Content completion deadline set** The project deadline for completing content is set for September 4th to allow for a phased release before the MacX event.
- **ROI content focus prioritized** The team will prioritize the Consequential ROI topic exclusively, deferring the Agent Wrangling topic until after the MacX event.
- **Content structure approach defined** Content will be structured as an overarching piece establishing an AI ROI framework and initial use case, followed by incremental parts detailing additional use cases.
- **Article topics selection finalized** The team will produce two specific articles: one addressing foundational investments required for AI success, and one detailing the specific challenges in calculating ROI for AI versus traditional software.

We've **updated the Decisions section** using your feedback.

Let us know what you think: [Helpful](#) or [Not Helpful](#)

Next steps

- ☐ [Rebecca Lyus] Pitch MacX Workshop: Pitch a 4-hour invite-only sidebar event for CTO and CFO roles to event organizers Holly and Jamie.
- ☐ [The group] Draft ROI Articles: Write 2 articles focusing on ROI for foundational investments and the unique challenges of ROI for AI use cases.
- ☐ [Rebecca Lyus] Coordinate Continuity: Loop relevant parties into project details to ensure continuity while out of office.
- ☐ [Ryan Lunka] Write article: Compose content regarding Return on Investment differences for the upcoming editorial series.
- ☐ [Jessica Dvoretz] Write article: Develop a piece concerning data hygiene and cleaning processes.
- ☐ [Andrew Kumar] Share calculator: Provide access to the Return on Investment tool once the current scaffold is prepared.

Details

- **Meeting Opening and Weather Discussion:** The meeting participants, including Rebecca Lyus, Jessica Dvoretz, and Ryan Lunka, engaged in brief informal conversation regarding local weather conditions and the regional impact of wildfire smoke, noting historical similarities to current atmospheric events ([00:01:13](#)).
- **Review of Previous Topics:** Rebecca Lyus opened the formal discussion by recapping the focus on "consequential ROI" and "agent wrangling," which were introduced in the previous week's meeting, noting that the team would prioritize the consequential ROI topic for immediate content creation ([00:04:57](#)).
- **Determining a Publication Timeline:** Rebecca Lyus discussed the timeline for producing content, suggesting a deadline to align with the working group's schedule. Jessica Dvoretz advised against publishing in August due to lower audience engagement in the US market, leading the group to target the period

between Labor Day and the MacX event on September 28th, with a final production deadline set for September 4th ([00:06:40](#)).

- **Content Strategy for ROI Topics:** The group discussed the format for the ROI content, agreeing to create a multi-part series. They decided to focus on an overarching framework with specific use cases, allowing for the potential addition of incremental use cases in subsequent publications ([00:09:06](#)).
- **Transitioning from Pilots to Enterprise AI:** Jessica Dvoretz and Dylan Valade emphasized the challenge of scaling AI pilots, noting that 70% to 90% of pilots fail when they are treated as personal productivity aids rather than managed enterprise software applications ([00:12:49](#)).
- **Governance and Business Outcomes:** Ryan Lunka addressed the governance gap, identifying that many teams lack the thought process required to forecast ROI for AI systems. The group agreed that a robust governance framework could help bound team efforts and guide them toward measurable business outcomes ([00:15:26](#)).
- **Categorizing ROI Metrics:** Andrew Kumar proposed categorizing ROI into "front-of-house" metrics, such as conversion rates and revenue growth for customer-facing experiences, and "back-of-house" metrics, which focus on cost reduction and efficiency in internal operations ([00:18:02](#)).
- **Distinguishing AI Implementation from Traditional Software:** Dylan Valade explained that AI implementation is fundamentally different from standard software projects, such as website rebuilds, because AI involves complex process mapping, handling non-deterministic outcomes, and managing data workflows that are not required in simpler software migrations ([00:20:21](#)).
- **The Role of Data Infrastructure and Trust:** Jessica Dvoretz highlighted that successful AI implementation requires a data intelligence or semantic layer, such as an ontology or knowledge graph. She argued that without this foundation, agents fail to produce accurate results, leading users to abandon the tools and revert to manual processes ([00:24:12](#)).
- **Addressing Maintenance Costs and the Dunning-Kruger Effect:** Ryan Lunka discussed the "Dunning-Kruger effect" in AI, where the perceived ease of initial development leads teams to underestimate the long-term complexity and maintenance costs. He noted that organizations often fail to budget for the perpetual ownership required to maintain AI systems ([00:28:03](#)).

- **Foundational Investments ("Eating Your Vegetables"):** The group discussed the tension between performing necessary "foundational" work—such as data cleaning and governance—and the pressure to deliver immediate, tangible value through AI use cases. They emphasized that skipping these foundational steps leads to failed deployments ([00:30:35](#)).
- **AI Governance as a Holistic Investment:** Dylan Valade and Jessica Dvoretz compared AI governance and infrastructure needs to the implementation of an Enterprise Resource Planning (ERP) system, noting that while such systems are often unglamorous, they serve as the necessary backbone for accurate and reliable operations ([00:33:41](#)).
- **Defining Deliverables:** Rebecca Lyus and the group decided to produce two distinct articles: one focusing on ROI for foundational investments and another on the unique nuances of calculating ROI for AI use cases ([00:36:00](#)).
- **Research and Validation Strategy:** Ryan Lunka emphasized the need for product-management-oriented research to understand the specific gaps and needs of the audience, rather than relying solely on the internal experience of the working group ([00:40:58](#)).
- **MacX Event Collaboration:** Dylan Valade proposed utilizing the upcoming MacX event to host a workshop or sidebar session. The goal would be to engage directly with CTOs and CFOs to gather real-world feedback and validate the team's hypotheses ([00:42:13](#)).
- **Administrative and Task Planning:** Rebecca Lyus planned to coordinate with event organizers to integrate this session and manage the project timeline before her upcoming leave. The team established that notes and resources would be shared via GitHub to facilitate co-working ([00:45:36](#)).
- **Authoring Assignments:** The group agreed that Ryan Lunka would lead the article regarding AI-specific ROI, and Jessica Dvoretz would lead the article regarding foundational data investments ("eating your vegetables") ([00:46:56](#)).
- **Progress on ROI Tools:** Andrew Kumar mentioned that they had begun scaffolding an ROI calculator based on existing data and would share a link with the group once it reached a presentable stage ([00:48:56](#)).

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Transcript

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00:01:13

Rebecca Lyus: Hello. How you doing, Ryan?

Jessica Dvoretz: Ryan,

Ryan Lunka: Hey, how are you doing?

Jessica Dvoretz: not bad. How are you?

Ryan Lunka: I'm all right. Got a thunderstorm going right now. So, looks like it's in the middle of the night on the camera.

Jessica Dvoretz: I mean, it's just dark and gloomy here. Where are you based?

Ryan Lunka: Columbus, Ohio.

Jessica Dvoretz: Columbus. Okay. I guess it's coming our way because I'm in New York. Typically, we get what you get 12 seconds

Ryan Lunka: You guys stay behind

Jessica Dvoretz: later.

Ryan Lunka: us.

Jessica Dvoretz: I think we're supposed to get the rain the storms like tonight into

Ryan Lunka: Is a welcome.

Jessica Dvoretz: morning.

Ryan Lunka: I We've had a fair bit of rain this year. has been welcome because sometimes in the summer, man, like when you're away from the lake in Ohio, it is just like 90s and dry for weeks at a time. It's

Jessica Dvoretz: Yeah,

Ryan Lunka: brutal.

Jessica Dvoretz: I feel like we for a few years were getting drought warnings, but not this year.

00:02:37

Ryan Lunka: Did you get any smoke from the wildfire or did it make that far?

Jessica Dvoretz: We did um I don't think it was as bad

Ryan Lunka: Yeah.

Jessica Dvoretz: because it kind of went like this and then we got it kicking up again. But it was creep like a few the wild smoke like four years ago turned the sky yellow.

Ryan Lunka: Mhm.

Jessica Dvoretz: This time it's just gray and creepy. be. And we got a red

Ryan Lunka: Yeah,

Jessica Dvoretz: moon.

Ryan Lunka: it wasn't as bad here as like Cleveland or Chicago, but my buddies who live in both of those cities were pretty freaky

Jessica Dvoretz: That's what it was like here.

Ryan Lunka: looking.

Jessica Dvoretz: Like it was four years ago, I think. It looked like the apocalypse. The sky turns this like yellow.

Ryan Lunka: It's crazy how far that travels. I went to we go to Park City every year because we have some family that lives out there and there was one year they had smoke from like a California wildfire which seems like so far away but you like couldn't see some of the mountain peaks in broad daylight because it was so hazy.

00:03:41

Jessica Dvoretz: I remember that that year I my I was at a company that um had a large office in Mountain View and those people were just freaking out. They smoked there.

Ryan Lunka: Yeah.

Jessica Dvoretz: There were there were apps about air quality and yes all

Ryan Lunka: That's a very mountain

Jessica Dvoretz: required data or all available data to model the optimal

Ryan Lunka: view.

Jessica Dvoretz: time to go to the

Rebecca Lyus: Hello everyone. We're just going to give it a couple more minutes. We don't have an ever with us today. Uh so just give it two more minutes before we start.

Dylan Valade: Hello. There was an interesting weather event that we had experienced in Germany where African storms had put all this red dust and sand into the air and then it blew over the Mediterranean and came down as snow as pink snow. So the whole whole Bavaria was covered in in pink in the middle of winter.

Jessica Dvoretz: Wow.

Dylan Valade: It was wild.

Ryan Lunka: My daughter would love it.

Dylan Valade: Yeah.

00:04:57

Dylan Valade: very princess type of uh

Rebecca Lyus: All

Dylan Valade: winter.

Rebecca Lyus: right, I think that is it for us. So, shall we get started? How's everyone doing? How's everyone feeling about the consequ consequential ROI uh topic that we were discussing last week?

Andrew Kumar: I don't remember. Uh, so I'm I was there notes I missed.

Dylan Valade: Great.

Andrew Kumar: I'm sorry. I was out of office.

Rebecca Lyus: Uh, let me just quickly pop the notes into chat so people can review. There we go. So to basically sum up, last week we were discussing the two focus areas that we were originally discussing. So consequential ROI and agent wrangling. We are eventually going to go on to agent rankling, but for now we are going to be writing some content regarding consequential ROI. So the main discussion was how are we defining ROI? Is it just financial? Is it resource such as people, time, tokens? ROI can be quite a broad subject. So we were trying to go over what do we want to cover?

00:06:40

Rebecca Lyus: Do we want to cover all of it? And that's how we are here. Now, to give the group a little bit of insight, the working group one is going to be producing their own buckets of stuff over the next couple of weeks to aim to be launched for the 11th of August. Did we want to match their timeline so that we can kind of go, we're also doing stuff. Here it is. Cuz I feel like we kind of need to set a deadline. It doesn't need to be the same deadline, but as actually going, we're going to produce something by this.

Jessica Dvoretz: Is there an advantage to being on the same deadline or does that um kind of like dilute the messaging?

Rebecca Lyus: Um, it's I've just pulled out the air because that is a date that I have on hand. We can choose our own time. So, we can go earlier, we can go later. I just need to give our marketing team a heads up so they can prep to promote it and I don't blindside them

00:07:51

Jessica Dvoretz: So for the US market perspective,

Rebecca Lyus: again.

Jessica Dvoretz: my bias would be never publish anything in August uh if you want eyeballs.

Rebecca Lyus: Okay.

Jessica Dvoretz: So I would say we should shoot for immediately a like shortly after Labor Day in the US which is I think September it's late this year it's September 8th but everyone's reputation from kind

Rebecca Lyus: Okay.

Jessica Dvoretz: of mid August at various points from mid August on but that might be a very US- ccentric perspective

Rebecca Lyus: No, that is completely fair and not one that I would have thought of to be honest cuz I don't know when Labor Day is. Um, so we have MacX on the 28th of September. So, we want to hit it in that sweet spot between Labor Day and the 28th. I wouldn't say the week commencing the 21st because we'll be publishing a lot about MacX and I don't want to drown out us talking about this. So shall we say our deadline to complete everything is going to be the 4th of September to then over the next two weeks release whatever we're publishing.

00:09:06

Rebecca Lyus: So if this is um cuz I know we've done a three-part series before now because of how much there is to talk about it, we could split it into how many parts we want.

Dylan Valade: I like

Jessica Dvoretz: makes sense to

Rebecca Lyus: Fantastic.

Dylan Valade: that.

Jessica Dvoretz: me.

Rebecca Lyus: So we now have a deadline. That's beautiful. Um, do we want to get both topics out or do we just want to focus on the ROI topic and then after MacX get the other topic out?

Jessica Dvoretz: That seems realistic to flip

Dylan Valade: It goes.

Rebecca Lyus: It does. And I'm happy to be realistic and as to drip feed rather than try and rush and then not

Jessica Dvoretz: them.

Rebecca Lyus: be happy with what we produce. So, we're going to do something to do with ROI. Now, how did we want to work this? Because we could do it as a setup to each uh time we have a meeting, we discuss this. Oh, I've just seen Andrew post something. Okay.

00:10:11

Rebecca Lyus: Um, do we want to do this as a multi-art series or do we want this to be as a single article?

Dylan Valade: But uh as I think about it, the way I engage with people when we're talking about return on investment, it is kind of by use case. And perhaps we would do maybe a multi-use case approach like here's an

Rebecca Lyus: Mhm.

Dylan Valade: example in a retail e-commerce environment. Maybe here's an example in a manufacturing product development environment. Something like that that you could bite into it and understand the business model. We could even have artifacts to help you do that. Spreadsheets that model the business and then you could understand what levers you want to pull. Whether that was growth in sales, cost savings, or like a value multiple.

Jessica Dvoretz: So maybe we have some sort of initial overarching piece with the framework and that includes the initial use case and then that gives us the opportunity to kind of add incremental use cases. is in subsequent

Ryan Lunka: I I agree with that.

00:11:26

Jessica Dvoretz: parts,

Ryan Lunka: It's going to sound disjointed if the examples are not built on a somewhat consistent

Rebecca Lyus: Okay.

Ryan Lunka: foundational like framework.

Jessica Dvoretz: but it seems ambitious to get the framework and the initial use case. So maybe we do the framework with a use case to support it and then that gives us the opportunity to

Rebecca Lyus: What's that?

Jessica Dvoretz: publish to your point Dylan other use cases kind of in a drip them out either before a mock or Faster.

Rebecca Lyus: Okay. Um, so what kind of framework are we wanting to set up?

Jessica Dvoretz: I mean, I think last time, if I'm like, as I'm restarting my brain and the coffee is hitting, um, we talked about going from experimentation with AI to scaling AI and scale, kind of it's like the world is moving from you know what is this cool AI thing let's go play with

Rebecca Lyus: Yes.

Jessica Dvoretz: it and different people in the organization are doing different things to kind of scaling an enterprise approach and um to do that you need to find a business ROI so kind of that was the setup I think we talked about and then scoping out how the measure the business might be able to think about

00:12:49

Rebecca Lyus: Yeah.

Jessica Dvoretz: it And I think we said maybe we talk about ROI from the perspective of different suite execs, but maybe now we're moving a different

Rebecca Lyus: Because at the end of the last meeting,

Jessica Dvoretz: direction.

Rebecca Lyus: you and Dylan were talking about the AI pilots moving to enterprise and you both said that it was 70 to 90% of pilots fail. Uh so we can definitely work on that cuz I'm just having a quick reread of the notes. Um, you guys said this involves treating these tools as software applications that are owned by the organization rather than personal productivity aids.

Jessica Dvoretz: and those require.

Dylan Valade: I can see an example.

Jessica Dvoretz: Go ahead,

Dylan Valade: I can see an example. This this would be a really good track and it's certainly timely.

Jessica Dvoretz: Dan.

Dylan Valade: We're lots of people inside of organizations right now are getting to the point that they do have their AI generated vibe coded assisted app and they want it to be leveled up and part of the the broader department or kind of cross team enterprise um suite.

00:14:17

Dylan Valade: So, if we can identify something, maybe it's it's a search and merch or customer service or something that I think is more also aligned with the MK Alliance membership like here's something we would want to take to prime time. This is where the data is going to live live. This is how it's going to be governed. These are going to be

the types of roles and decisions that would be made. And then you you could build up that agentic flow. walk through how to do it and then um so I think it's a combination of like kind of proof it out and write the business case that would go with it and say here's why we would need to build out the enterprise structure to to support this app in production. This is who would probably run it and this is what you would expect for a payback and over what period of time.

Jessica Dvoretz: Ryan, I think in that case we're bumping up a little against your governance topic, right? which is what do you need to do to under to centrally understand

00:15:26

Ryan Lunka: Yes. I don't know if I view them as all that binary.

Jessica Dvoretz: right I mean I I didn't I actually was like that would be a way to incorporate it because I think

Ryan Lunka: Yeah. Yeah.

Jessica Dvoretz: um to get the ROI there are certain centralized investments you need to

Ryan Lunka: Yeah, the biggest governance gap that I have experienced so far

Jessica Dvoretz: Hey,

Ryan Lunka: is um I don't even know if I describe it as a traditional governance problem. It's more like so many teams don't even know how to like have that thought process in place to think about business outcomes and try to forecast an ROI for the investments into an AI system. And I think my theory case is that the right governance framework can actually bound teams who otherwise don't intuitively know how to do that. by narrowing those narrowing the playing field to some extent and giving us some guidance on how to get there. Does that make sense how I'm saying

Jessica Dvoretz: Yeah. So, Rebecca, I mean,

Ryan Lunka: it?

00:16:39

Jessica Dvoretz: I think there's I think there's idea is that it's been the wild west of a/c development in many companies. there's now a desire to go from these whether they be formal pilots or kind of informal um you know I don't know what the right word is like lead um or experimental people within the organization and what does the organization need to do to build the business case for really centralized governed investment in AI Okay, that might bring it all together. And please everyone correct me if you disagree, but that kind of I think brings it together.

Dylan Valade: It's coming together nicely.

Jessica Dvoretz: Andrew,

Rebecca Lyus: Yeah.

Jessica Dvoretz: you've been conspicuously quiet.

Rebecca Lyus: Heat.

Andrew Kumar: I don't I don't conspicuously I I've just been I've been thinking per I've been reflecting

Jessica Dvoretz: Take it up.

Andrew Kumar: cuz like I'm like I have I have some data that I'm referencing and in my back of my mind I'm a lot of the there's almost I'm I'm seeing maybe two buckets of ROI but it's still pretty early and that's so as you're talking I'm just contemplating right there there's kind the front of house ROI.

00:18:02

Andrew Kumar: This is very Bloomish perspective by the way, so apologies in advance. Um, the front of house is like the shopping assistant. So, the ROI happens when a customer can find what they're looking for faster on an e-commerce experience or can find information or arrive at a purchasing decision. Um, so the ROI there, it's very much like conversion rate and revenue increase. Um, and there is like a speed advantage. how fast can someone find what they're looking for and how much

you can lower friction. Um, so those are kind of standard consumer ROI metrics, but then um on the agentic side, there's also a lot of back office metrics of like how f how much faster can you do a job with an agent doing a task on your behalf instead of you clicking and configuring or ingesting or doing a lot of manual steps and stages. Um, so we almost I don't know. That's what there's there I kind of think of it like there are front of house metrics and there are back of house metrics and then how do we how do we um and and to a certain degree the front of house metrics tend to focus on revenue up and the back of back of house metrics tend to focus on cost down.

00:19:13

Andrew Kumar: I'm I'm generalizing but that that's what I'm percolating as you guys are talking like how do we structure this?

Ryan Lunka: Well,

Dylan Valade: Merchandising cuts both ways.

Ryan Lunka: I don't it I think I think most ROIs you're going to find will cut both ways or you could make an argument that many of them will like that. Do we feel like it's necessary to rearticulate how to calculate an ROI? Because it doesn't really matter what technology or any initiative you're talking about.

Andrew Kumar: Yeah.

Ryan Lunka: ROI is ROI. There's you're going to make capital one-time investments. You're going to make potentially ongoing marginal investments as you use whatever the thing is, and you got to weigh that against what sort of cost cutting and or revenue opportunity that the thing opens up. And it's just about plugging in reasonable assumptions to get to the numbers that you expect and then tracking against it. And that's that's ROI universally speaking. So it strikes me as more important to focus on what is particularly challenging, unique, idiosyncratic about AI systems in terms of plugging in those assumptions to build an ROI model.

00:20:21

Ryan Lunka: But the concept of ROI is the same it's always been.

Dylan Valade: Yes, there maybe is an element where there's a feasibility kind of assessment for that organization and a way to say we're ready to tackle this particular problem because yes, we do have this data set readily available. Yes, we do have a way to run this in production. Um, and yes, we do have a willing staff that's like change management is not going to be a problem. If those are nos, then it's going to be a hard slog and maybe look for different opport opportunity. So even though the numbers make sense, the feasibility is nearly zero. I guess maybe the big difference for me in a lot of the technology discussions about this type of investment is that that people don't understand what types of things are different about doing this than say a website rebuild uh just a a software package migration and then it is fundamentally different.

Jessica Dvoretz: Can you articulate like a little more about why what makes it fundamentally different than a software than a website

00:21:47

Dylan Valade: Um there's I guess maybe not all of the examples,

Jessica Dvoretz: rebuild?

Dylan Valade: but the way that I'm uh so let's say it's a a merchandising example because I brought that up. Um, and I'm not a merchandiser, but having watched those teams, there's a heavy Excelbased workflow. Uh, they need to be forecasting what to buy and plan based on one like what the company thinks is going to be right, what the product teams like physical product teams think they need to build, and then what are the market dynamics, what's changing. There's a lot of inputs to come in that they're supposed to understand each cycle. That's just a heavy load. That's great for AI. Also, it's it's unclear what's going to happen. So, there's there's prediction there with a human agreeing or disagreeing. What's the prediction? That's a data science like advanced analytics problem. And then that's an easy one where people might say, let's hand that off to an agent. And then on the the other side, you actually have to sell through like did

we were we successful and if not what can we do to move this product and then again you've got a whole different kind of data set and set of actions and people involved.

00:23:13

Dylan Valade: Now I'm thinking about like marketing people at the end of the funnel trying to close or clear out product that's over stock. Now, those types of decisions are really good for a multi-agent workflow and could hand off nicely to something like Bloom Reach. Here's what we've got available. This would be the margin on it. These are the things that we want to push by market. So, when I look at a problem like that versus I'm going to move from whatever Magento to Shopify, which is also like a lot of the common project types. They're they're just different. there aren't all these handoffs. You don't really need to understand the process as much end to end because you already know the process. So that process mapping is key to it. And then understanding where can I handle this part of the process automatically. How would I capture a decision that's made? How would I log out and audit that this thing has happened and happened predictably or if it's not deterministic.

00:24:12

Dylan Valade: It's going to be probability based that we captured that as well. There it's different in that way where you've got new things to try to solve for. They've been solved but maybe not ever by your company.

Jessica Dvoretz: So basically what you're saying is rather than changing the tools that the team is working with which is like Magento to Shopify, right? It's the same things that teams are doing. you're just changing the the system in which they're working. This is actually trying to understand how people work and um and then something that we we would

Dylan Valade: Yeah.

Jessica Dvoretz: spend a lot of time talking about is like what is actually in the systems and what is tribal knowledge and how do you give AI that tribal knowledge, right? How do you codify the relationships between data instead of just the data itself? I think that's what a lot of people skip.

Dylan Valade: Correct.

Jessica Dvoretz: So we at ECUM we have um a data intelligence layer, a semantic layer. We use like an ontology and a knowledge graph.

00:25:21

Jessica Dvoretz: And we think our point of view is that if you don't have whether ours or build your own or you know you're not going to get accurate um consistent and token efficient results and the first thing that's going to happen is no one's going to trust your agent and then it's going to like rip out. Then that's why your pilot fails, right? because um it comes up with it missed something and so when the team goes to validate the answers they don't like them and then they go back to Excel.

Dylan Valade: You nailed it. That's exactly what I was thinking. And you it

Jessica Dvoretz: I lived in merchandising for a long time so I was feeling like why I would hate

Dylan Valade: perfectly.

Jessica Dvoretz: that. You you picked the use case for me. Okay. So, it sounds like what we want to talk about is not maybe there's a small part on sizing ROI because like that's not that different, but we're actually talking about from theoretical ROI to achieving ROI. What is different in achieving the I ROI from an AI implementation versus a software implementation?

00:26:41

Jessica Dvoretz: Does that sound right?

Dylan Valade: it does to me. Happy to hear from the group.

Jessica Dvoretz: And then implementation requires um a different level of understanding and a set of investments in. governance and data and whatnot that you might not have thought about before because they weren't required um in your last five uh software implementations or something like that. I don't know. I'm I'm talking

Dylan Valade: I I really this this for me sounds like exactly the conversations that have been useful. I'm curious to hear from the rest of the group though like is this tracking for you? Is this missing something?

Rebecca Lyus: Yeah, it sounds good. It sounds like we're getting somewhere.

Jessica Dvoretz: So I think from I mean you so um Ryan, Dylan, Rebecca, you're probably coming from an SIM uh perspective and so these are the conversations you're

Rebecca Lyus: Yeah.

Jessica Dvoretz: having as an ISV. be in the market. These are some of the things that we're like trying to help people understand because they they want to believe it's easy.

00:28:03

Jessica Dvoretz: Um, you know, they want to believe it's just like run like it's like what they've done before and it's not and so how do we make them so we don't get to necessarily have the conversations in the same way you do, but it's certainly what I wish people understood.

Ryan Lunka: So, I'm I'm kind of thematically hearing two things that relate but are not exactly the same thing. So, tell me if I'm misharing this. There is. So, I agree that there's like this massive Dunning Krueger effect with AI because one, it's so easy to do a bunch of stuff individually like immediately that you just everybody just like thinks they understand it all kind of intuitively. Um, and I agree with you also and they don't want to accept the complexity of doing it at scale and a production quality, right? Or maybe don't have their head around it because they it's just so new. Um, and so that causes two problems. One of which is when defining an ROI model for any AI initiative, um I do find people drastically mispredict or misforecast costs specifically the ongoing cost of maintenance and and like tuning of an AI system.

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Ryan Lunka: Um or you know the other side of that is they think they just it worked once, we put it out there, cool, we're done. not the like no no no no you have to own and babysit this thing for basically perpetuity. While it might trail off eventually like there's a lot of work there and so you misallocate the cost of ownership.

Rebecca Lyus: What's

Ryan Lunka: Um two there is also a conversation about

Rebecca Lyus: that?

Ryan Lunka: foundational investments like an ontology or like data cleanup or data unification or whatever efforts are required given the context. There's these like underlying foundational investments that need to be made and that is an underappreciation. conversation and how do you talk about those in terms of ROI especially if they aren't attached to like a concrete initiative that they are eventually going to enable but not

Jessica Dvoretz: Yeah.

Ryan Lunka: today.

Jessica Dvoretz: And it's how do you demonstrate that the use cases generate enough ROI to pay for these investments because those

Ryan Lunka: Mhm.

Jessica Dvoretz: investments in the governance and the data are ultimately what you'll then be able to really quickly build agents get a lot of use cases and unlock those ROI.

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Jessica Dvoretz: But you can't just play in the use case because that won't deliver the ROI that you think it will. But you if you talk about the platform without the use case, then no one wants to spend the

Ryan Lunka: Yeah, I think there's like a really serious tension there too and I struggle with it because

Jessica Dvoretz: money

Ryan Lunka: on one hand you want to tell everybody to eat their vegetables and fetch your data and get it prepared to do all these things. On the other hand, if you just tell everybody to eat your vegetables, but we don't get to do any of the stuff that actually delivers cool value or tangible value, then like that problem has existed pre AI. Nobody solved it already because nobody wants to eat their vegetables. So, how do you how do you balance those two statements so you're not

Jessica Dvoretz: And I think and then I think the the

Ryan Lunka: yolo mode and you're not don't do anything before you do the the work you didn't want to do already?

Jessica Dvoretz: addition is how is AI different?

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Jessica Dvoretz: Like there are so many ways that people in the organization compensated outside the systems for the vegetables you didn't eat. But AI is not going to do that. AI just goes fast. If you feed if you if you don't govern AI,

Ryan Lunka: Yeah.

Jessica Dvoretz: it will go rogue faster than an employee will. If you feed AI bad data, it will make bad decisions faster than an employee would. Um, and so like,

Ryan Lunka: it will always do a thing no matter what.

Jessica Dvoretz: yeah,

Ryan Lunka: So,

Jessica Dvoretz: it will always do something. It won't stop and be like,

Ryan Lunka: like I actually thought about this the other day,

Jessica Dvoretz: wait, something doesn't look right.

Ryan Lunka: like if anthropic put out a model that was actually trained to be like, "No, I don't have enough information for that request. Let's work on that first." They'd be they'd win the air at risk.

Jessica Dvoretz: because it will just find whatever it thinks works best,

Ryan Lunka: Continue,

Jessica Dvoretz: right? And so like the um the cheats that you had for not eating your

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Dylan Valade: But

Ryan Lunka: right?

Jessica Dvoretz: vegetables in a pre-All world, suddenly the cost is a lot higher.

Ryan Lunka: Mhm.

Dylan Valade: there are data quality options though like you you can insert those steps and they could even be customtrained or just just rulebased and

Jessica Dvoretz: 100%. You just need to invest in that and not skip that.

Dylan Valade: right so then that would that's an option though it's like part of play. play is you can if your data is not in a position where you can just hand it over to existing off-the-shelf or frontier AI solutions then you would need this step either you build a team and you get serious about this or you do a one-time custom thing to clean this up so you have a pipeline that's stable predictable and and good enough for the decision You can

Jessica Dvoretz: 100%. That's that's half my definition of eating your vegetables, right? Like so there's,

Dylan Valade: stop

Jessica Dvoretz: you know, there's cleaning up your data, managing your data, governing your data, and then and then kind of governing your organization.

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Dylan Valade: the understanding of that holistic investment and the actual effort to get to success is that was part of the business case. I guess the ROI that has been invisible and if that's abstracted as a percent or a number of people per problem or something that that might be helpful as a way for people to think about it because it's true what you said is right like it is far more complex and there's new pieces we just didn't have to deal with before it was a SharePoint or Oracle or a whatever for a 0365 thing. It just these are different problems that we haven't generally been budgeting for and planning for inside of a company. And it's not even clear who owns it because sometimes whoever brings in the vendor is responsible for the vendor. But in this case, it's so crosscutting. You need somebody at a higher level.

Jessica Dvoretz: It's almost like the ERP, right? Like the ERP is right everyone.

Dylan Valade: Yeah.

Jessica Dvoretz: How do you justify the cost of the ERP? No one wants it.

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Jessica Dvoretz: Everyone hates it. But it is your source of truth. It is the backbone of your company.

Dylan Valade: It is the yin and yang to the ERP. That That's a good way to look at it.

Jessica Dvoretz: All right, Rebecca, help us. I think we've got like a ton of like we've moved so far. So much great thinking.

Rebecca Lyus: Yeah,

Jessica Dvoretz: How do we take this to what we need to deliver?

Rebecca Lyus: that is where I was just about to jump in because we are now halfway through our call. We've got some fantastic topics. Now, we need to fuel this energy. What would help you guys the most? Do you need there to be because we have our GitHub and we can pop stuff into it, work on projects? Would it be easy to co-work in

there, would you rather have like a Google sheet where people can just come in and add things? Everyone works a little bit differently. So what

Ryan Lunka: I don't I don't know if the I don't know if the ways of working are so much the gap as the definition

00:36:00

Rebecca Lyus: works?

Ryan Lunka: around what the deliverable is

Rebecca Lyus: Okay.

Jessica Dvoretz: Yeah.

Ryan Lunka: like are we are we aiming for more articles style output like blog posts effectively or are we aiming for something

Rebecca Lyus: Yes. Yeah.

Ryan Lunka: more concrete like an ROI calculator or a white paper or a structured presentation? I don't like

Rebecca Lyus: So the great thing about this working group is we can decide what we want to do.

Ryan Lunka: what

Rebecca Lyus: So if you want to build an ROI ROI calculator, let's do that. If you want to do a white paper, we can do that. I'm not here to dictate what you do do. I'm here to facilitate it.

Jessica Dvoretz: I think we start with the article because that's like the easiest for lack of a better word.

Rebecca Lyus: Okay.

Jessica Dvoretz: And if we if in doing that it turns into a it may naturally turn into a white paper just because we keep saying and this and this and this um and it might might naturally

Rebecca Lyus: Yeah.

Jessica Dvoretz: grow and then I think it wherever we land would then create the direction for the

00:37:21

Rebecca Lyus: Yes.

Ryan Lunka: Okay. Well, that I think two article ideas have surfed here. It's the same two I said before.

Jessica Dvoretz: calculator.

Ryan Lunka: One is how do you think about ROI for the foundational investments that are required to make AI

Rebecca Lyus: Okay.

Ryan Lunka: successful when they're not necessarily attached to a use case? And then when you're building an ROI for an AI use case, what's what's going to get you? What's different this time? Those are two tangible things that could be written articles.

Rebecca Lyus: Perfect.

Jessica Dvoretz: And in your mind, what's different about a white paper? Just what what what would be the angle for a white paper?

Rebecca Lyus: Oh,

Ryan Lunka: Uh, I would expect a white paper probably to be a little bit more backed by some data. I mean like look you could put a bunch of opinion pieces together in a PDF and call it a white paper certainly

Rebecca Lyus: evil.

Ryan Lunka: but like typically the most compelling white papers that I have read have been heavily justified with like tangible data or tangible examples um versus just like an opinion piece or like a a guidance piece.

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Jessica Dvoretz: So then I agree we start with the those those two articles or happy to debate what the articles are but I liked those um because I think those will then give us the framework. Do we want to go collect data against one of those and then it becomes a white paper or do we want to move to a calculator or something like that? And we might actually need to collect the data to get to a

Rebecca Lyus: Yeah,

Dylan Valade: That would be a good working session.

Rebecca Lyus: Cuz what they

Dylan Valade: at the mock event like

Rebecca Lyus: trying to

Dylan Valade: to in invite some brands to come in and sit down with the group and walk through

Rebecca Lyus: get?

Dylan Valade: this process and ask what do you need next? Let's work through some of this for

Rebecca Lyus: Yeah.

Dylan Valade: you.

Rebecca Lyus: cuz who would be the people we would want to do research with or would we want this to go out to the wider audience so we're not biased? Cuz that is the balance. Now, if we're wanting to gather this research, we can easily set up a form, put it out there, get this research.

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Rebecca Lyus: We have so many different members, so many different levels of people from people who are admins doing the work to CTOs who are overseeing it.

Jessica Dvoretz: I mean, I'd like to understand CTO's and CFOs personally like CTO's,

Rebecca Lyus: Okay.

Jessica Dvoretz: how many of them understand this? How are they reconciling it in their head? CFOs, how are they thinking about the investments in AI? Like, are they the same? Like, are those two people even on the same page?

Rebecca Lyus: cuz I can facilitate us reaching out to the CTO's and CFOs we have that are end users and that are members and pick their brains. Um, we just need to set up the questions. But if we're working on these articles, I feel like the questions are going to come out of that. Like we'll be able to flesh this

Jessica Dvoretz: I think we do the articles and then that's the kickoff to the

Rebecca Lyus: out

Jessica Dvoretz: research

Rebecca Lyus: and then we'll either do a white paper or a calculator or both afterwards.

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Rebecca Lyus: So we'll do it in that phased approach.

Ryan Lunka: So there's sort of two layers of research we're talking here that are not exactly the same thing. One would be collecting some amount of data to create a more databacked perspective on whatever topics around AI ROI we decide on. In my opinion, the more important area of research that we should be doing is more product management oriented where we're instead of us trying to like triangulate what the market needs from our experience in this closed circle here, we we have a direct understanding from the people we're hoping to serve. What gaps do they have? What do they questions they need answered? what can we provide them to to move them forward? Like the the analogy here, you know, going back to my ISV days, similar to where you're at, Jessica, like you don't just get in a room and be like, well, the product should do this, right? Like you have to do pretty intense customer research and hypothesize about what the market actually is going to pay for before you start coding all this stuff or you just build a bunch of stuff and then hope somebody buys it and most of the time they don't.

00:42:13

Ryan Lunka: And like we're kind of falling into that trap here a little bit because we don't have any context from the perceived audience about what actually would be helpful for them.

Jessica Dvoretz: Is that a way we could use Mox Mach X? Like if we have the articles published and we turn that into a PowerPoint or something, could we facilitate a session at MockX around what how this is happening in the ambassador organizations or what they're struggling

Dylan Valade: Yeah, exactly. That's what I was thinking by workshop. Ryan, you described it perfectly.

Jessica Dvoretz: That's

Dylan Valade: Let's let's pause the the small group think

Rebecca Lyus: Okay.

Dylan Valade: tank, take it directly to the people that need to put all of the mock membership to use for a real business outcome and see where they're at.

Rebecca Lyus: Yeah.

Dylan Valade: This is also two months from now. The world could potentially be very different.

Rebecca Lyus: Yep.

Dylan Valade: So then we we get real feedback and then it the concern I have is that we're going to go too far on theory and miss the boat on action.

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Dylan Valade: So if we get in front of these people quickly and we all sit down together, work through some of these problems, I think we'll have a really good mind

meld and then that that might be enough research to just get to the next stage and whatever that looks like as an artifact or set of them.

Ryan Lunka: Yeah,

Dylan Valade: Or maybe it's just a handoff.

Rebecca Lyus: Yeah.

Ryan Lunka: I don't I don't think that disqualifies working on some conceptual think pieces in the meantime, right?

Rebecca Lyus: Yeah.

Ryan Lunka: Like you don't we don't have to do nothing until we have information. But like yeah,

Rebecca Lyus: Nothing.

Ryan Lunka: I would be I'd be very hesitant to be like, let's invest all this time in this research white paper or building another freaking ROI calculator behind a pay wall or, you know, one of these other like things we could do without more information about what's even going to be helpful.

Rebecca Lyus: Yeah. Okay. I have a chat with Holly tomorrow morning. I and with the wider group organizing MacX in the afternoon so I can get an answer to this pretty quickly.

00:44:18

Rebecca Lyus: Um, I'm just opening up our agenda as well, which uh because we've got the hackathon planned during the lunch period, I will need to see I currently see a gap and I'm going to see if I can force our way in there.

Dylan Valade: Oh,

Rebecca Lyus: Um

Dylan Valade: Rebecca, I would consider pitching this to Holly, Jamie, whoever that this might be a sidebar like where this is not part of

Rebecca Lyus: yeah.

Dylan Valade: the formal e agenda and that this is a 4hour Power. or type separate thing invite only looking for CFO CTO type roles.

Rebecca Lyus: Yeah.

Dylan Valade: We were looking at that specifically for the Toronto one to try to find a way to bring seuite there and we just didn't have enough time and frankly didn't have a good conversation planned but I think we do this time.

Rebecca Lyus: Okay. I will see what I can do. Um, it will need to be this week and as soon as possible because I am by at the end of this week I'm going to be out for a couple of weeks.

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Rebecca Lyus: Um, so I'm going to try and speedrun this with those two with Holly and Jamie.

Dylan Valade: Perfect.

Rebecca Lyus: And yeah,

Dylan Valade: And you can send it my way if that's helpful.

Rebecca Lyus: I'll also loop everything so that it doesn't get stalled just cuz I'm out.

Jessica Dvoretz: Great.

Rebecca Lyus: I feel like we're currently at a conclusion.

Jessica Dvoretz: So, what do we need to do to get those articles going?

Rebecca Lyus: Um,

Jessica Dvoretz: Maybe that's in a how we work. So, we know we want to author these two articles.

Dylan Valade: parse the transcript from this meeting and you'll get 50% of it.

Rebecca Lyus: Uh I will put the notes and transcript links into uh GitHub under meetings so people can access them.

Jessica Dvoretz: Can you send me the GitHub again, please? I know I have it somewhere.

Rebecca Lyus: Uh I will quickly pop it into chat now and I will also pop it into the

Jessica Dvoretz: Amazing.

Rebecca Lyus: Slack channel. Um, just so we have ease of access in both locations.

Jessica Dvoretz: Thank you so

00:46:56

Rebecca Lyus: Not a problem.

Jessica Dvoretz: much.

Rebecca Lyus: Who wants to take the lead on the articles?

Ryan Lunka: Last time we did an article, I just wrote one and then people provided input. So there's two ways to think about this. One is you team up on an outline and then decide who's going to produce the actual pros of the article. Another is you have one person write the article and then other people provide feedback relative to that. Um I don't I don't think any one of those ways is necessarily better or worse than the other. It's just a how much time do people want to contribute to it?

Rebecca Lyus: Perfect.

Ryan Lunka: I'm I'm more than happy to contribute significantly to one of the articles. I'm probably a little bit more uh qualified or focused on the um what's different about the ROI than the foundational ones right now just because of where my head space is at for non-mock related things. But

Rebecca Lyus: Okay,

Jessica Dvoretz: I can help on the what you need to do to like the data part of eating your vegetables.

00:47:58

Rebecca Lyus: fantastic. then well volunteered.

Jessica Dvoretz: I don't know if that's the whole article or if that's part of an article,

Rebecca Lyus: Uh we can make a start and see where it goes with

Jessica Dvoretz: but

Rebecca Lyus: that because we have time. We can work around it as well. So if you get partway through and get inspired to go down a different tangent, that's not an issue. It's

Ryan Lunka: based on the general length of the so the first one we wrote was pretty big and that's why it got split into three um and so like the mock editorial standards the articles are pretty short so I think there's a bigger risk in having too much content that needs to be split up than not enough for an article I think you guys only have like a thousand word articles or 1500 word articles or something like that,

Rebecca Lyus: Yeah,

Ryan Lunka: right?

Jessica Dvoretz: Got

Rebecca Lyus: we're quite short.

Jessica Dvoretz: it.

Ryan Lunka: So like one very concrete topic is probably adequate for an article is my

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Jessica Dvoretz: Okay,

Ryan Lunka: point.

Jessica Dvoretz: I can take a stab at, you know, eating your vegetables and cleaning your data. Then we can figure out how it fits into the umbrella.

Rebecca Lyus: Yeah. All right. Um, does anyone need any help with anything with any of the research or resources that you're currently working on? Are you

Andrew Kumar: All good. I started to scaffold an ROI calculator just to see how how it comes together with the data we have right now.

Rebecca Lyus: happy?

Andrew Kumar: So, I'll I'll let you I'll I'll send a link when it's looking decent.

Jessica Dvoretz: Amazing.

Andrew Kumar: to Medicaid.

Rebecca Lyus: Sounds good. All right. Well, we have 10 minutes, so take some time back. Enjoy. Make a cup of tea.

Jessica Dvoretz: And have a wonderful vacation, Rebecca. I've done talked to you before.

Rebecca Lyus: Thank you. All right. Speak to you next time.

Ryan Lunka: Hi everybody.

Tomasz Pindel: A good one.

Rebecca Lyus: Bye.

Dylan Valade: Thanks.

Andrew Kumar: Thank you.

Tomasz Pindel: Bye.

Andrew Kumar: Thanks everyone. Cheers. Hey. Hey.

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